

MAHINDRA & MAHINDRA

High potential candidates get strategic training in soft skills and cross-cultural sensibilities.

"We found it difficult to make a presentation to the Daewoo team during due-diligence as all the material was in Korean."

RAVI KANT, MANAGING DIRECTOR, TATA MOTORS



IN AUGUST COMPANY: Mahindra with his Chinese staff

give a presentation to the Koreans. The Tatas hired an army of translators and interpreters and within 72 hours, all the audio visuals, group brochures and other relevant material in English were translated into Korean and sent across to the management. Daewoo employees were also treated to a variety of Indian cuisine at an Indian evening.

Integration exercises are, however, more than just noodles and curries. Human resource maxims like compensation, benefits and training of employees are equally in vogue once the pay packets and skill sets have been figured out. The inherent risks are of an exodus. When M&A deals fail to achieve anticipated synergies, there is every chance of talent fleeing the company.

Corporates like Apollo Tyres, Wipro and Tatas are thus arranging regular exchange visits of their employees. Tatas have even had the labour unions from Jamshedpur visit the Corus facility to send out a message about their work culture. DRL, which has shifted the head of the en-

gineering unit in Roche, Mexico, to Hyderabad to integrate the skills and fill in the gaps in its Indian plants, has not lost a single person despite high attrition elsewhere in the industry. "This is without any loyalty bonus or golden handcuffs," says Jha.

Medium and small scale firms are not far away. International Print-o-Pack (IPP), a printing and packaging company eyeing acquisitions in Europe, plans to shift its shop floor ac-

tivities to India given the cost efficiencies. Since there is a strong women workforce in the target company, it plans to offer work-out-of-home-facility once they arrive in India. The IPP management is also keen to extend its open-door HR policy to the expat workforce. For instance, the practice of setting aside an afternoon slot of 2-3 p.m. for employees to interact with the senior management. Surinder Kapur, CMD, Sona Koyo Steerings, has the German management of ThyssenKrupp still leading the business strategy in marketing. Kapur stays connected with the staff through e-mail. "There is a great deal of pride and excitement in being able to exchange mails with the group chairman. I am inundated with mails thanking me for making them feel like one big family," beams Kapur.

Vijay Mallya's mantra is not to impose his people on the acquired team so as to foster confidence. Mallya has only three representatives in Whyte & Mackay, the rest are French. He allows employees to compete for various management positions. It has helped in getting people's loyalty to the company, explains Nedungadi.

Arcelor Mittal managers were horrified to see Soviet style compensation packet in their acquired company in Poland. They have promptly switched to an annual variable pay structure to stir the workers into action. In London, Anup Sahay, chief integration officer, Tata Steel and his team have made comforting gestures like retaining the two-day weekend compared to the Indian six work days. With Corus in a poor shape due to long years of debt and low morale, plenty of fun and recreation has been introduced even in the midst of serious work, in a true Indian style.

Marriages may be made in heaven but not of the business kind. Though Indian companies have woken up to the demands of peoples integration, there is still scope for adopting global practices to make the earthly unions work better.

BONHOMIE: Kapur with his German family

**SONA KOYO STEERINGS**

Surinder Kapur is swamped by mails from the ThyssenKrupp team thanking him for making them feel like one big family.